The past simple: regular and irregular verbs

Goal: By the end of this lesson, you will be able to narrate the life of a famous person in the past simple, using regular verbs with -ed and the correct forms of irregular verbs in affirmative, negative and interrogative sentences.

The idea in two lines: The past simple describes finished actions at a definite past time (*in 1830, last year*). Regular verbs add **-ed**; irregular verbs have a second form to learn by heart (*go → went, write → wrote*).

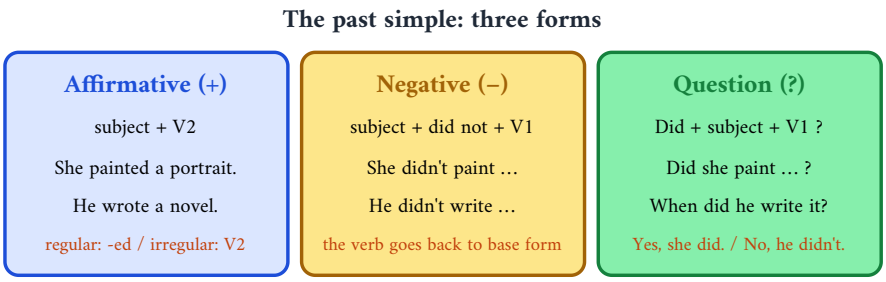


Figure 1: The affirmative uses the past form (V2); the negative and the question use "did" and the base form (V1).

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Use:** a completed action at a definite past time, with *yesterday, ago, in + year, last …*. *Emir Abdelkader was born in 1808.*
2. **Regular verbs:** base + **-ed**: *work → worked*. Consonant + y: *study → studied*. One vowel + one consonant: *stop → stopped*.
3. **Irregular verbs:** learn the second column: *be → was / were, go → went, write → wrote, become → became, win → won, leave → left, teach → taught*.
4. The past form is the **same for all persons**: *I / he / they wrote*. Only *be* changes: *I / he / she / it was; you / we / they were*.
5. **Negative:** *didn't + base form. She didn't win the prize.* With *be*: *wasn't / weren't*.
6. **Questions:** *Did + subject + base form? Where did she live?* With *be*: *Was he famous? Where were they born?*

7. **Pronunciation of -ed:** /t/ (*worked*), /d/ (*lived*), /ɪd/ after t or d (*painted, needed*).

🟢 Examples

1. Put the verb in the past simple: *Mouloud Feraoun (write) novels about Kabyle village life.* **Answer:** wrote. **Explanation:** irregular verb; the past form is *wrote*, not "writed".
2. Make the sentence negative: *Leonardo da Vinci finished all his paintings.* **Answer:** Leonardo da Vinci didn't finish all his paintings. **Explanation:** after *didn't* the verb returns to the base form.
3. Ask about the underlined words: *She moved to Cairo in 1950.* **Answer:** When did she move to Cairo? **Explanation:** question word + *did* + subject + base form.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Double past: "He didn't *went*", "Did she *wrote*?" After *did*, use the base form.
- Adding -ed to irregular verbs: "goed, teached, becomed".
- Confusing *was* and *were*: "They *was* born in Tlemcen."
- Writing the base form in the affirmative with a past time marker: "In 1962 Algeria *become* independent" instead of *became*.

🟡 Quick review

- Finished past action with a definite time → past simple.
- Regular: -ed (studied, stopped); irregular: learn V2.
- Negative: didn't + V1; question: Did + S + V1?
- be: was (I, he, she, it), were (you, we, they).
- -ed is pronounced /t/, /d/ or /ɪd/ (worked, lived, painted).